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A moratorium requires regulations

Theresa **Duckett 24.** JD @ Tulane Law School, BA in English from DePaul University, "Pressing Pause: Answers to Seven Frequently Asked Questions About Moratoriums". xx-xx-2024.

<https://fsbrlaw.com/2023/03/31/pressing-pause-answers-to-seven-frequently-asked-questions-about-moratoriums/>. elimafia 🧑

1. What is a moratorium?

"Moratorium" is often a **loaded word**, especially in the context of land use and zoning. Although some may associate "moratorium" with the word "ban," "moratorium" is defined by Black's Law Dictionary as "[t]he suspension of a specific activity." See MORATORIUM, Black's Law Dictionary (11th ed. 2019). When applied in the township law context, a moratorium is typically used as a temporary time period of a year or less to pause consideration and permit issuance related to a specific topic (e.g., signs) while a township develops new regulations to better address the topic. See e.g., Cent Adver Co v St Joseph Tp, 125 Mich App 548, 555; 337 NW2d 15 (1983).

2. Why would a township enact a moratorium?

Townships often impose moratoriums for issues that are not adequately addressed by current township ordinances. For example, the popular Lake Michigan tourist destination near Chicago, New Buffalo, Michigan, enacted a moratorium on all permit applications and registrations of short-term rental units (e.g., rental units like those on AirBnB that are rented generally for periods less than one month). *Moskovic v City of New Buffalo*, No. 1:21-CV-144, 2022 WL 16548948, at *1 (WD Mich, October 31, 2022), reconsideration den No. 1:21-CV-144, 2023 WL 179680 (WD Mich, January 13, 2023).

The aff would mirror the AOC act – it's the only real proposal and prevents data centers from increasing utility bills, pollutants, and taking subsidies

Legisletter 26 (Legisletter, 3/25/26 [Legisletter is grassroots advocacy software that helps mission-driven organizations grow their supporter base, educate advocates on key issues, and influence U.S. lawmaking] "S. 4214: Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act" <https://legisletter.org/bill/s4214-artificial-intelligence-data-center-moratorium-act//SF+//RG>)

S. 4214, the Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act, is one of the most aggressive AI infrastructure bills introduced so far. Sponsored by Senator Bernie Sanders, it would freeze construction and upgrades of large AI data centers starting the day it becomes law. The freeze covers a lot. A facility is caught if it's used to develop or run AI models at scale, or if it pulls more than **20 megawatts** and either feeds 20 kilowatts to a single server rack or uses liquid or immersion cooling. That definition captures the kind of campuses tech companies are racing to build right now. What makes this bill unusual is that the freeze has no expiration date. It lifts only after Congress passes new laws that do several things at once: set up federal safety review of AI products, put policies in place to prevent AI job loss and share the wealth, and require that any future data center add no cost to consumer utility bills, cause no environmental harm, win local community approval, take no government subsidies, and use union labor with prevailing wages and apprenticeships.

The Big Great Overview.

Mineo '26 [Liz; Harvard Staff Writer; 4-9-2026; "Why are communities pushing back against data centers? — Harvard Gazette"; Harvard Gazette; <https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2026/04/why-are-communities-pushing-back-against-data-centers/>; accessed: 8-12-2026] citrus 🍊

Data centers, which house computer systems that help train AI models, **are blanketing the country**, a boom fueled by surging interest in AI and state tax breaks.

More than 4,000 are already in operation, mostly in **Virginia, Texas, and California**, **and 3,000 more are being planned or under construction**.

Data center developers and tech giants argue the projects benefit communities by creating new jobs and boosting local economic development through increased property tax revenue and future business opportunities. They also note that infrastructure must grow if the nation wants to remain a global AI power.

But public opposition is mounting over the large water and electricity demands and other strains that data centers, often the size of warehouses, place on communities, according to a recent poll by the Pew Research Center.

In this interview, which has been edited for length and clarity, Ben Green, assistant professor in the University of Michigan School of Information and Public Policy and a faculty associate at the Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society, discusses the impact of data centers on communities, the factors behind their rapid expansion, and the potential for regulation.

Residents are increasingly pushing back against plans to build data centers in or near their communities. Are their concerns legitimate or exaggerated?

The **public** broadly is quite **negative** about **data centers**. Overall, their **concerns are very legitimate**.

The public is concerned about **rising electricity rates** caused by data centers. They are **concerned** about the **enormous water use** that **data centers require**. They're concerned about **public handouts in the form of tax breaks** that are going to **data center developers**, and **they're also aware that data centers don't bring meaningful economic development**, especially in the form of jobs.

I think the public is quite right to be concerned about data centers. My research and other research have shown that **these are a bad deal for communities on the local level**.

"I think the public is quite right to be concerned about data centers."

It's been impressive **just how well communities have organized** around this, **how educated** they have gotten about the topic, and **how many of these projects** they have been able to stop. It's a sort of **David and Goliath** fight; **local communities** are pushing back against some of the **wealthiest companies** in the world.

Certainly **not every effort is successful**. Sometimes, **the wealth and power of these companies win out**. But many data center projects have been blocked by local resistance, and many municipalities have passed moratoria that pause data center development.

How much water and electricity do data centers require on average?

The standard definition of a hyperscale data center is that it is more than 10,000 square feet with more than 5,000 servers. **But even that is way below the current standard of the data centers that are being built today**.

Just a few miles from where I live in Ann Arbor there is a big project, part of **OpenAI's Stargate Project** in Saline Township, Michigan, where the plan is for it to be **over 2 million square feet and use 1.4 gigawatts of energy**. That is **equivalent to the energy use of a million households**.

What is important here is not just the scale of an individual data center, but also the number of data centers that are being developed at rapid pace across the country, which is fueling a massive expansion in energy and water demand.

Estimates suggest that within a couple of years, the electricity needed for data centers is going to be around 10 to 15 percent of total nationwide electricity demand. This means that the data center boom is putting severe strain on efforts to move the country toward renewable energy sources, often by prolonging the use of fossil fuel plants that had been slated for closure.

Data center developers claim they bring jobs to local communities. What's your take on that?

It's a significant false promise of these data centers. Developers say this because they know that it is attractive to policymakers; they come asking the state to give them benefits in the form of tax breaks, reduced regulations, or special zoning permissions in exchange for job creation.

That also allows data center developers to play into this idea of spreading the aura of the tech economy and Silicon Valley across the country by saying, "We can bring a taste of Silicon Valley to Michigan or Ohio or Colorado."

"It's a significant false promise of these data centers."

In practice, this is not what happens. The construction of data centers requires work because these are large construction projects, but that lasts a year or two; sometimes that labor is local and unionized, and sometimes that labor is trade professionals who come in from other states.

Once the data center is up and running, it requires very few people, often just 20 to 50 staff members, because it's not an office for software developers, product managers, or marketing experts. It is a warehouse of servers.

Do tax revenues and other community benefits outweigh the downsides of data center expansion?

Unfortunately, there's just very little economic development that plays out on the local level.

There is some tax revenue, but even that is reduced because of tax break policies. Over the last year, Virginia and Georgia have given up more than a billion dollars' worth of revenue as a result of tax breaks. That's money that is being handed back to the industry rather than going into public funds that could pay for infrastructure, schools, or healthcare.

Also, there are not beneficial ripple effects like you might see with other industries. Living within a stone's throw of a data center does not mean that you are getting better or faster or cheaper access to these technologies.

Communities in both blue and red states have pushed back against data centers. Why is this an issue that unites communities regardless of their political leanings?

Data centers are becoming an important issue in local, state, and potentially federal elections because it is an important subject for voters. They can really feel how data centers affect their lives in ways that are tangible and concrete.

And it's causing some interesting realignments and potential for bipartisan coalitions because it's not a simple left or right issue. Liberals and people on the left are concerned for environmental reasons and distrust in AI companies, but many conservatives are upset about data centers too.

This introduces a sort of wild-card effect into future elections where being critical of data centers is a big winning issue for candidates. That played out in November in some Virginia and Georgia elections and is a hot topic for candidates campaigning right now, such as in the Michigan Senate primaries.

What policy recommendations are needed to address the expansion of data centers?

Regulation is definitely necessary. One important action is to **repeal tax breaks for data center developers** because they are **incentivizing further data center development** and are making it a further **bad deal for communities**.

A large number of projects are happening because states have passed tax breaks to incentivize data center development. About **35 states now have these tax breaks in place as part of their recruitment pitch**.

There are many other considerations.

First, **transparency needs to be a bare minimum requirement**. There's an **amazing** amount of obscurity in data center development right now. **Contracts are secretive, and when they are made public, there are huge redactions, and policymakers are signing nondisclosure agreements**. There should be early and consistent transparency about what's being proposed and what the terms of these deals are.

There should be rate protections for consumers with clear contract provisions such that the cost of upgrading the utility infrastructure to service a hyperscale data center doesn't get passed on to consumers like you and me, which has been happening consistently across the country.

If you live near data centers, your electricity bills are going up, often by a factor of two or more. There should also be a stronger voice for communities in determining whether to welcome data centers, and under what conditions.

One final piece is the need to think about broader planning on how much total water and electricity demand from data centers a state or a region or utility jurisdiction can handle. **It's one thing to say that a state can handle one hyperscale data center, but quite another for that state to be welcoming dozens of such facilities**.

We have to make sure that **we're not sacrificing climate goals** just for the sake of building more data centers or building data centers faster. **We should not be allowing the desire among the tech industry for rapid data center development to push renewable energy goals to the wayside**.

Subpoint A is Agriculture:

Data centers compete with agricultural land---raising prices and demand for resources

Higgins & Nelson '26 [Autumn Lankford, Bernt; Director of Government Affairs, Economist; 4-23-2026; "Balancing Data Center Growth with American Agriculture"; FB; <https://www.fb.org/intel/markets/balancing-data-center-growth-with-american-agriculture>; accessed: 8-13-2026] citrus🍊+ //SF

Demand for data centers – large, secure facilities that house computers and servers used to store, process and manage vast amounts of digital data – **is accelerating as cloud computing, artificial intelligence and other digital services expand across the United States**. These facilities form the backbone of the modern economy, powering the internet and enabling the applications and services relied upon by businesses, governments and everyday consumers. **According to Data Center Map and analysis by AFBF**, it is estimated, that **there are 4,925 active or under construction data centers across the U.S.** These **facilities**, often **requiring hundreds of megawatts of power** are **increasingly sited in rural areas** where **land availability, energy access and proximity to transmission infrastructure make development feasible**.

The scale of investment is significant. Construction costs range from \$9 million–\$15 million per megawatt, meaning a typical 250-megawatt facility can cost between \$2.3 billion and \$3.8 billion, while the price tag for larger campuses can reach tens of billions of dollars. These projects are not just industrial developments; they are long-term infrastructure commitments that shape local economies for decades.

Demand for data centers, driven by the growth of artificial intelligence (AI), high performance computing and cloud service adoption, is continuing to outpace U.S. supply capacity. According to a study by Goldman Sachs, in 2025 U.S. demand for data center capacity outpaced supply by about 11.4 gigawatts or about 43%. The study forecasts the capacity supply to increase by 150%, from 26.7 gigawatts in 2025 to 66.7 gigawatts by 2028. Even with this rapid growth, 2028 demand for capacity is forecast to outpace capacity supply by 10.4 gigawatts or about 16%.

For agriculture, this trend presents both opportunity and risk. Farms and ranches depend on land, water and energy, the same inputs data centers require at scale. At the same time, agriculture increasingly depends on the digital infrastructure data centers provide.

The central question is how to integrate them into rural America without compromising agricultural productivity and community stability?

Why It Matters to Agriculture

Farmland is the foundation of agricultural production and a generational asset for farm families. Once converted to industrial use, it is rarely returned to production. In regions experiencing rapid development, the cumulative loss of prime farmland is a growing concern.

At the same time, modern agriculture is deeply connected to the digital economy. Precision agriculture, cloud-based management tools, and real-time data analytics all rely on robust data infrastructure.

This creates a dual reality:

Agriculture depends on data centers for innovation and efficiency.

Data centers are increasingly competing with agriculture for access to land, water and energy.

Land Values and Site Selection

Site selection for data centers is about more than just finding available land. Land for data centers is treated as critical infrastructure that is selected based on several qualities or characteristics. Some key factors involved with site selection are the proximity to stable, high-capacity power grids, access to major fiber routes for high-speed data transfer, risk for natural disasters, climate conditions that could reduce cooling costs, and regulatory or tax incentives.

Virginia and Texas are the two leading U.S. states for data center development, with 706 and 546 data centers active or under construction, respectively. Virginia, particularly northern Virginia, is home to the world's largest data center market due to elite fiber connectivity, tax incentives and affordable, reliable power. Texas is in second place for U.S. data center markets due to its low energy costs, abundant land, regulatory environment, independent power grid, and tax incentives. In Texas and Virginia for example, qualifying data centers are exempt from state and local sales tax on hardware, software, cooling systems and emergency generators. Electricity and fuel used by qualifying Texas data centers are also exempt from sales tax.

Developers often seek agricultural land as it is often already cleared, graded and laid out in large contiguous tracts, lowering upfront site development costs and shortening project timelines relative to more complex greenfield or urban sites.

Zoning flexibility in rural areas, where agricultural land can be rezoned for industrial use with relatively few barriers, is another factor driving data center site selection. While this flexibility can support economic development, it also introduces a form of land use competition that extends beyond individual sales. As more parcels are rezoned or considered for rezoning, farmland begins to carry speculative value tied to future development potential, increasing both purchase and rental costs for active farmers. Over time, this dynamic can shift local land markets

away from agricultural production and toward development-driven pricing, even in areas where little land has been converted. In these high-demand regions, prices for land can reach millions of dollars per acre.

Dakotafest, August 18-20, 2026

The sale of agricultural land for data center development can also affect land values elsewhere in the state or across the country. Through the use of section 1031 of the tax code, landowners may defer capital gains tax from the exchange of a like-kind asset. This allows, for example, a farmer to sell their farmland for data center development and then to reinvest in farmland elsewhere in the state or country, potentially driving up the value of farmland.

Resource and Infrastructure Pressures

Energy Demand

Electricity expenditures on U.S. farms have risen sharply in recent years and are forecast to increase by 48%, or \$2.8 billion, from \$5.75 billion in 2019 to \$8.5 billion in 2026, according to USDA's Economic Research Service. Growing electricity demand from data centers, electrification and digital infrastructure is adding pressure to an already aging grid. The Department of Energy estimates data centers used about 4.4% of U.S. electricity in 2023, a share projected to rise to between 6.7% and 12% by 2028.

Total electricity demand is expected to increase over the coming years, requiring significant investment in transmission, substations and generation capacity. These costs are often recovered through higher electricity rates, though utilities are increasingly using tools such as large load tariffs to help manage infrastructure expansion and limit impacts on other customers. Ensuring grid investments expand capacity without shifting disproportionate costs onto farm operations will be important for maintaining the competitiveness of U.S. agriculture.

Water Use

Cooling systems for data centers can require substantial amounts of water, which raises concerns in agricultural regions where water supplies are often limited. Increased demand can lead to competition for scarce water resources and create risks for local watersheds. While emerging technologies, including more water efficient cooling systems, such as closed loop cooling, offer ways to reduce these impacts, transparency around water use and accountability measures remain essential to maintaining trust and protecting shared resources.

Rural Economic Development: Promise and Tradeoffs

Data centers can offer meaningful economic opportunities for rural communities, including increased local tax revenue, job creation and the potential revitalization of areas facing economic decline. However, the economic benefits are not guaranteed and can vary widely depending on location and planning. Without careful consideration, communities may also face unintended consequences, including rising costs of living and strain on existing infrastructure.

Key Policy Considerations

The American Farm Bureau Federation (AFBF) supports responsible data center development in rural areas that delivers meaningful economic benefits while respecting local resources and private property rights. State and local policymakers play a critical role in balancing growth with long-term land preservation by recognizing farmland as a strategic economic asset, protecting against unnecessary conversion of highly productive agricultural land, and prioritizing brownfields or previously developed sites whenever possible.

Because data center projects often move quickly and can outpace local planning processes, strong local governance is essential. Transparent zoning and permitting decisions, along with early and consistent engagement with landowners and other stakeholders, help ensure that communities have a voice in development decisions and that outcomes reflect local priorities.

AFBF also emphasizes the importance of responsible resource management. Data centers should be located and operated in ways that protect agricultural water resources, including clear disclosure of water use and the adoption of water-efficient technologies such as closed-loop cooling systems. Policy frameworks should address shared demands on critical resources by encouraging continued innovation in water efficiency, supporting energy infrastructure that benefits both agriculture and data center operations, and promoting solutions that strengthen the resilience of rural communities overall.

Bottom Line

Rural communities can support both agriculture and responsible data center development, with farmers, ranchers and landowners ultimately deciding how their private property is used. Smart site selection, local engagement, and long-term planning can ensure rural America remains both a hub for agricultural production and a partner in responsible technological growth.

With thoughtful policy, strategic siting and strong local engagement, rural America can serve as both a global leader in agricultural production, and a critical partner in the digital economy.

Land prices are 5x more expensive

Nargi '26 [Lela; journalist covering food and ag policy, social justice, and climate-related science for outlets such as The Guardian, Knowable Magazine, and Yale Environment 360; 1-3-2026; "This Land Is Their Land"; Ambrook; <https://ambrook.com/offrange/land/not-farming-data>; accessed: 8-13-2026] citrus 🍊

"Life-changing money." That's how Wendy Reigel describes the windfall developers are offering farmers for their land, potential sites for hyperscale data centers to meet AI's massive processing needs. Reigel is a grassroots anti-data-center activist who successfully fought the building of a center just 300 feet from her house in Chesterton, Indiana; she now helps other communities mobilize against data center incursions. She can only make an educated guess as to how much money is on offer — almost everything about these facilities is shrouded in secrecy.

"\$20,000 an acre would be low-balling it," Reigel said. "\$40,000 would be maybe a starting point. And I've heard as high as \$90,000."

From the Pacific Northwest to the Northeast, communities are seeing a surge of tech-center buildouts as American tech leaders embark upon what Wired magazine called a "battle for AI dominance." New executive orders from the Trump administration will eventually ease environmental permitting and other barriers to these builds — there have been three such orders since January 2025. And with this wind beneath their sails, AI-giddy companies like Amazon, Google, Meta, Microsoft, and Oracle have embarked on a national land grab.

Legislators often welcome data centers for their promise of jobs, infrastructure development, and increased tax revenue and property values — rewarding developers with tax breaks and weak regulations. Meanwhile local residents decry them for guzzling water, driving up energy costs, fouling the air, churning out noise pollution, and causing land prices to skyrocket. (In some instances, land prices surpass Reigel's guesstimates: Developers are paying \$150,000 an acre for farmland in Ohio, \$400,000 an acre in Utah.)

Some farmers are loath to condemn fellow farmers who sell their land for this purpose. They don't begrudge life-changing money to anyone who's contended with their industry's often brutal fiscal realities, although a farmer in Michigan who sold his land for an "astronomical" sum — in the interest of what he called progress — says his neighbors don't wave at him anymore. With or without the animus, farmers who opt not to sell are left to contend with the potential destruction of their operations and their lives. "It ruins all our little farms around here that we worked all our lives on," a couple in Coweta, Oklahoma, told the local news.

There are data centers popping up almost everywhere, from Oregon and Nevada to Georgia and Virginia. (Loudon County is our country's "data center alley.") But Indiana has become an especial target for hyperscale facilities, of which there are an estimated 1,130 globally; since Indiana produces a lot of corn, soy, and hogs, it's also illustrative of the challenges that farmers in particular are up against.

"It ruins all our little farms around here that we worked all our lives on."

"Of the 40-something [data centers] that we're tracking" in the state, "most of them are in ag areas," said Bryce Gustafson, program organizer for environmental nonprofit Citizens Action Coalition (CAC). He's not sure what the exact implications are for food security although he noted, "Last I checked, we can't eat data or AI."

Even before data center developers started to swarm, farmland in Indiana was going for about \$15,000 an acre, according to Kiley Blalock, who married into a third-generation row crop and beef-producing family some 30 miles east of Indianapolis. At first, she said, **private equity firms** were the eager buyers.

"That hurts us, because they're paying a higher price than market value for the land; that drives property values up, then farmers are struggling to pay their taxes," Blalock said. That price is also "completely out of reach" for any farmers starting out or looking to expand their operations. When data centers are willing to quadruple or quintuple an already-inflated price, affordability for farmers goes up in smoke.

Growing pressures on farmland drive public health risks, food insecurity, and unaffordability

Nicome '26 [Anthony; public health and environmental justice strategist and serves as an advisor to the National Academy of Medicine Climate Communities Network; 6-24-2026; "Op-ed: AI Data Centers Are a Threat to Local Food Systems"; Civil Eats; <https://civileats.com/2026/06/24/op-ed-ai-data-centers-are-a-threat-to-local-food-systems/>; accessed: 8-14-2026] citrus🍊

There are now more than **3,000 data centers** in the U.S., along with more than 1,500 facilities in development. While these centers power the digital economy, they also consume **extraordinary amounts of water** to cool servers, sometimes withdrawing **millions of gallons** per day in regions already strained by drought or groundwater depletion. Their **massive electricity consumption** can **stress regional grids**, push **communities** toward more **polluting energy sources**, and drive up **energy costs**.

In Texas, Michigan, New Mexico, Wisconsin, Pennsylvania, and many other states, the centers are taking over large swaths of farmland or flat, open parcels that would otherwise be ideal for farming, community gardens, orchards, or green space. In central Washington, we're already seeing data centers replace family orchards that produce some of the state's most iconic crops, like cherries.

As these centers proliferate, they are placing growing pressures on agricultural land access, water availability, and local energy costs—factors that can affect local food production, food affordability, and long-term food-system resilience. If we want to protect our food future, we must protect our farmland.

Food Producers on the Front Lines

As an environmental justice advocate, I am deeply troubled by where and how we're building the backbone of our digital future. The physical infrastructure of AI is increasingly dropped into places that can't absorb the costs.

Rural Mason County, Kentucky, is a case in point. Farmers and residents here are fighting a proposed hyperscale data center project that could consume thousands of acres of farmland deeply tied to the region's agricultural identity and generational heritage.

Unlike traditional data centers, which are generally 100,000 square feet or less, hyperscale data centers are massive facilities that can cover 200,000 to several million square feet and consume as much energy as some cities or even U.S. states. They house thousands of servers and support cloud computing, artificial intelligence, and other large-scale digital services.

Farmers here have reportedly been offered millions of dollars for their land, but many have refused.

"You can't get food out of a data center," local farmer Ida Huddleston told People. "Everything comes from the land. Once you tear it up, you can never replace it again." She and her family ultimately declined a \$26 million offer for their land.

"Everything comes from the land. Once you tear it up, you can never replace it again."

Community members, including farmer and Germantown City Commissioner Max Moran, have warned in a recent podcast that the proposed hyperscale data center could impact roughly 2,100 acres of productive farmland, and if the zoning changes are approved, other centers are poised to follow, potentially impacting as many as 10,000 acres here.

They say data centers threaten not only water resources, energy infrastructure, and quality of life there, but also the long-term survival of family farming. They worry about the project's limited transparency, too—some city officials signed nondisclosure agreements—and the noise and traffic.

For Moran, the fight is deeply personal. When interviewed for the podcast, he stood on land his family has farmed for at least six generations, reflecting on a heritage that stretches back further than he can trace.

“Money isn’t everything, and the real value when it comes to the land is being able to pass it down to your next generation,” Moran said.

The loss of farmland here, say Moran and other locals, would erode nearby food production capacity, dismantle agricultural heritage, and accelerate the disappearance of rural farming communities already under pressure nationwide.

“I think people should know that it’s taking up a lot of the farmland where their food comes from,” Jonathan Bowles, a Mason County fifth-grader, told WCPO 9 news.

When Data Centers, Food Systems, and Public Health Collide

The buildout of data centers on farmland could be especially damaging in regions with marginalized communities that already grapple with food insecurity and environmental burdens such as air and water pollution. Every acre converted into an industrial complex is an acre lost to potential farms, community orchards, or green spaces that help residents access fresh, affordable food. This would include Indigenous communities with ties to land that goes back thousands of years, and for whom land is synonymous with well-being.

A lack of viable land impacts residents’ ability to raise or gather their own food, further driving negative public health outcomes. Weakened local agriculture means fewer farmers’ markets, school garden programs, and community food hubs, and more reliance on long, fragile supply chains.

When water is scarce or diverted, growers struggle. When energy costs rise because of growing demand on local power infrastructure, the cost of refrigerating, transporting, and processing food increases as well. Siting data centers in vulnerable communities already impacted by environmental inequities could further degrade their health and safety and erode their ability to feed themselves affordably and sustainably.

A Call for Oversight

Perhaps most troubling, the data center boom is unfolding as federal environmental oversight weakens. Recent cuts to environmental research and environmental justice programs have reduced support for community engagement, impact assessments, and climate initiatives. Communities now have even fewer resources to challenge harmful projects or advocate for better alternatives.

If we are serious about food justice, environmental justice, and public health, then we must challenge the rapid, largely unregulated buildout of data centers. Communities deserve transparency, participation, and power over what gets built in their backyards and how it affects the resources they depend on.

This begins with comprehensive, cumulative impact assessments that examine how data centers affect water availability, air quality, land use, agricultural capacity, energy demand, climate resilience, and public health. These assessments must be rigorous, public, and conducted before any permit is approved.

Data center impacts are inherently local. Therefore, community engagement beyond public comment periods is key. Counties and municipalities, for example, should work with community-led organizations to establish data-center oversight boards. These boards should bring

together residents and representatives from permitting, environmental, and public health agencies, local universities, and community-based organizations.

“Data center impacts are inherently local. Therefore, community engagement beyond public comment periods is key.”

Such bodies can ensure that the lived experiences of residents, particularly those in communities most likely to bear the impacts of development, are reflected in decision-making, planning, and accountability efforts. Local governments should also require ongoing public reporting on data center water use, energy consumption, and environmental impacts.

Legislative measures can be taken to protect farmland and potential community food-producing spaces. For example, in Skagit County, Washington, local officials recently placed a temporary ban on new data-center applications specifically to prevent the loss of farmland and protect water resources.

Agricultural parcels, green space, and land critical for local food access should be off-limits for data center development. If data centers truly must be built, they should be placed in areas that cannot support agriculture or local food production, rather than in the spaces capable of sustaining it.

The facilities themselves must be designed sustainably. From the earliest stages of planning and design, the facilities should incorporate emerging best practices for integrating renewable energy, water-efficient cooling technologies, and waste-heat recovery systems that can supply energy for nearby buildings and communities. And while efforts are underway, these approaches remain largely experimental and unproven at scale.

Finally, we need robust research on how AI infrastructure interacts with food systems and public health. That means studying land-use changes, water withdrawals, agricultural displacement, pollution, and the cumulative effects of clustered data center development. Without this knowledge, we risk making decisions blind to their long-term consequences.

The tension unfolding in Mason County and across the country illustrates a fundamental truth: People want a future shaped by innovation, but that future must value their health, water, land, and right to feed their families. Technological progress should not come at the expense of community survival.

We do not have to choose between innovation and nourishment, technology and equity, or progress and public health. We only have to choose to plan wisely and listen to the communities who have always understood that the land beneath their feet, the water they drink, and the food they grow are worth more than anything a data center can offer.

Expensive and rapid acquisition drives insecurity

Davis et. al. 14 (Kyle F Davis, Paolo D’Odorico, Maria Cristina Rulli [Department of Environmental Sciences, University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA 22904 USA, Department of Environmental Sciences, University of Virginia, Charlottesville, Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering, Politecnico di Milano, 20133 Milan, Italy] PMC. “Land grabbing: a preliminary quantification of economic impacts on rural livelihoods” DOA: 8/13/26, <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4223572/> //SF)

Global demands on agricultural land are increasing due to population growth, dietary changes and the use of biofuels. Their effect on food security is to reduce humans’ ability to cope with the uncertainties of global climate change. In light of the 2008 food crisis, to secure reliable future access to sufficient agricultural land, many nations and corporations have begun purchasing large tracts of land in the global South, a phenomenon deemed “land grabbing” by popular media. Because land investors frequently export crops without providing adequate employment, this represents an effective income loss for local communities. We study 28 countries targeted by large-scale land acquisitions [comprising 87 % of reported cases and 27 million hectares (ha)] and estimate the effects of such investments on local communities’ incomes. We find that this phenomenon can potentially affect the incomes of ~12 million people globally with implications for food security, poverty

levels and urbanization. While it is important to note that our study incorporates a number of assumptions and limitations, it provides a much needed initial quantification of the economic impacts of large-scale land acquisitions on rural livelihoods.

Otherwise, millions are at risk of death.

Ross 24 [Steven Ross, Public health reporter @ US News, 1-29-2024, Food Insecurity Tied to Shorter Life, Early Death, US News & World Report, <https://www.usnews.com/news/health-news/articles/2024-01-29/study-food-insecurity-tied-to-shorter-life-early-death>]

People who experience food insecurity are at greater risk of dying prematurely and living a shorter life

after age 50, researchers say, underscoring how a fairly prevalent problem can impact individual health. The federal government says food insecurity refers to “limited or uncertain access to adequate food” – an economic and social condition that can lead to hunger. In an analysis published Monday in JAMA Internal Medicine, researchers found 78.4% of more than 57,400 U.S. adults included in the study were fully food secure, compared with 8.5% who had marginal food security, 7.4% who had low levels of food security and 5.6% who experienced very low food security. **Researchers also found estimated life expectancy at age 50 was 32.5 years among individuals with full food security, compared with 29.9 years among adults with marginal food security, 30 years among those with low food security and 28 years among individuals with very low food security.** That means adults with very low food security lived 4.5 years less once they turned 50 than those with full food security, and researchers said about half of the lost life expectancy could be attributed to deaths from cardiovascular disease and cancer. The analysis, based on survey data from 1999 to 2018, additionally **found an association between even marginal food security and a 50% higher risk of premature mortality, defined as a death occurring before a person turns 80.** “The present findings may have a great public health implication,” researchers wrote. “Our results suggest that in addition to encouraging people to improve their lifestyle and cardiovascular health, improving food security may also be a way to curb the stagnant life expectancy of U.S. residents.” The new findings come on the heels of provisional data from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention showing average life expectancy in the U.S. rebounded in 2022 by a little over a year following two straight declines, fueled largely by a drop in mortality tied to COVID-19. Overall life expectancy at birth rose from 76.4 years in 2021 to 77.5 years in 2022. By gender, the new study found women with very low food security lived an average of 5.8 years less at age 50 compared with women with full food security. Men with very low food security, meanwhile, had a life expectancy three years shorter than men with full food security at that age threshold.

Subpoint B is Subsidies:

Data centers take billions in subsidies---local regulations fail

Garofalo ‘26 --- (Pat Garofalo [Director of state and local policy at the American Economic Liberties Project], 1-13-2026, "The Cult of Data Centers", No Publication, <https://boondoggle.substack.com/p/the-cult-of-data-centers>, doa7-24-2026) citrus 🍊 + Nepal 🇳🇵

This is, to put it mildly, long overdue. While a nationwide total is not possible to ascertain — because 14 states that subsidize data center construction do not disclose their total losses — we know that **four states are losing at least \$1 billion annually to data center tax subsidies**, while **another six are losing at least \$100 million annually**, and **dozens more have losses totaling millions of dollars every year.**

So that’s **billions of dollars** on an annual basis, at least, **to subsidize** the necessary **business infrastructure of an industry** that is **one of the most profitable** not just in the country, but in the history of the world.

As I've written several times before, the case for subsidizing data center construction is weak at the best of times. Data centers don't need many permanent workers, they create no knock-on economic development effects, they are often a net negative for their neighbors because of noise and aesthetics, and they have the potential to increase costs for water and electricity across entire states and regions if not managed correctly.

Yes, new data centers generate revenue for many communities, but so would other economic development projects that do a better job of promoting the needs of local businesses or workers. While the tech industry for a while successfully promoted data center development as an extension of Silicon Valley, that tactic has clearly run out of gas (due to it being false) and communities are now more likely to battle an impending data center project than welcome it.

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A recent Politico poll, in fact, showed that 41 percent of Americans would oppose a data center being built within three miles of their home, while just 24 percent — less than a quarter — would be in support. With those kinds of numbers, politicians swinging against the direct subsidization of the industry makes perfect sense.

But there's also a broader argument about the goals of economic development to be made here: The case for publicly subsidizing an industry — any industry — is that it provides something worth having in a particular place, something that is in the state's, county's, or municipality's interest to incubate because it adds long-term economic value. That support should, in theory, be temporary, existing only long enough for the industry in question to build enough of a foundation that it can stand on its own and provide local benefits without being a permanent ward of the state.

That, quite obviously, has not happened with data centers (nor with most industries subsidized in the name of economic development). Even if you make the argument that the data center industry was worth supporting in its early days due to the high revenue potential, those days were many years, if not decades, ago. Virginia, the undisputed data center capital of the Earth, is still subsidizing data center construction through tax exemptions that were first enacted in 2008, and legislators in this year's budget chose to continue that support.

If the industry can't stand without subsidies in Virginia, which has a higher concentration of data centers than anywhere else on the planet, then where can it? What's the point of fostering an industry that needs to be subsidized in perpetuity, other than lining the pockets of executives and lobbyists? And if the argument is that the industry is so transient that failure to continue subsidizing it will result in its departure, was it even worth fostering in the first place? No! It was not!

To be clear, most of the "pauses" and "bans" being implemented at the state level don't get at the full extent of the problem, either because they don't cover all of the various avenues through which data center developers or operators can claim tax breaks, including property tax abatements or other local exemptions, or because they don't cover other ways in which the public subsidizes data centers, such as through discounted power or water. Many pauses also are not retroactive, so projects that were rushed into the application process before they took effect will still be able to claim money.

Repealing subsidies unlocks billions in revenue AND is the first step for communities to negotiate real benefits.

Elmo '26 [Anthony; public education funding defender with Good Jobs First; 05-20-2026; "Managing the AI Onslaught: Nix Data Center Subsidies — Center for New York City Affairs"; Center for New York City Affairs;
<https://www.centrernyc.org/urban-matters-2/managing-the-ai-onslaught-nix-data-center-subsidies>;
accessed: 8-13-2026] citrus 🍊

Public officials need to stop treating Big Tech projects as prizes to be won and start treating them as transactions to be governed. Too much economic development policy chases famous corporate names with large subsidy packages, when the better strategy is investing in public goods that help many employers: schools, infrastructure, workforce training, small businesses, and local industry capacity.

The issue is not whether every data center should be opposed. Communities need digital infrastructure. Construction workers need work. Cities need property tax revenues. The question is whether some of the richest corporations in the world should get to use public assets on private terms.

The scale of Big Tech's own spending makes the subsidy argument weaker. Just five companies — Alphabet/Google, Amazon, Meta/Facebook, Microsoft, and Oracle — have announced more than \$710 billion in AI capital expenditures in 2026. Companies in that kind of buildout are not waiting for a county tax abatement to decide whether the AI economy needs servers. They need them. The public should negotiate from that fact.

Good Jobs First has long warned that data centers are not ordinary economic development projects. Hyperscale facilities can consume hundreds of acres, require enormous amounts of electricity and water, generate noise and air pollution, and receive large tax abatements. That scale of public burden should change the scale of public demands.

Start with the money. Tax abatements are not free. They are public spending through the tax code. When a city, county, or school district gives up revenue, that money is no longer available for classrooms, safety, libraries, parks, roads, housing, public health or basic services. When a state exempts data center equipment, building materials, or power purchases from sales taxes, local governments usually lose revenue too, and with no say.

Worse, in many places the public cannot even see the bill.

Good Jobs First reports that 14 states and scores of localities fail to disclose how much revenue they lose to data center tax abatements. In states that do report, losses are soaring: Georgia, Virginia, and Texas each lose \$1 billion or more per year. That is not economic development strategy. It is spending without a budget.

The first reform is simple: Disclose the cost. Every state and locality that loses revenue of any kind to a data center tax abatement should report that loss in its Annual Comprehensive Financial Report.

The second reform is simpler: Stop subsidizing data centers.

Amazon, Microsoft, Facebook, Google, Apple, and other tech giants are not deciding whether they need data centers. They are racing to site them — in lots of places. Tax incentives are for industries that need help: These facilities are core infrastructure for companies worth trillions of dollars, not fragile start-ups or mature companies struggling to modernize. The best incentive policy is to repeal the tax breaks and require companies to pay their full freight.

That means full taxes. It also means fair energy prices and no utility tax abatements. Before communities even talk about “community benefits,” data center companies need to pay sales and property taxes and be placed in separate utility rate classes so households and small businesses are not forced to subsidize new power capacity built for hyperscale demand.

Good Jobs First made the same point about Amazon warehouses: When a corporation is coming because its business model requires it, governments should not pay it to arrive. They should turn the tables. Amazon needed warehouses near customers. Today, Big Tech needs data centers near land, energy, fiber, and markets. In both cases, the question is the same: why should taxpayers subsidize what the company already needs to do?

Public officials need to look at the world the way AI executives do, not the way site-selection consultants want them to. The companies know they must build. They know power, land, water, fiber and public approvals are increasingly scarce. With polls showing that 69 percent of Americans don’t want a data center near them, the companies also know they have fewer and fewer options. That is why communities should not give away leverage at the front door.

Process reforms come first. Communities cannot negotiate benefits for a project they are not allowed to understand. That means no nondisclosure agreements. No project code names. No mystery end users. No rushed votes before residents know how much electricity and water the project will use, how many polluting backup generators it will need, what subsidies are requested, what infrastructure upgrades are required, and what jobs will actually be created.

Then come the benefits — real ones, not corporate-washing. Community Benefits Agreements can be powerful tools. But they can also become a donation here, a STEM photo op there, a few charitable checks used to distract from a bad deal.

A real community benefit agreement cannot be a side letter attached to a subsidy giveaway. It must be enforceable, negotiated early, and tied to the actual costs of the project: infrastructure impact fees, energy and water protections, noise and pollution mitigation, public reporting and clawbacks if companies fail to deliver.

Then come job quality standards. Data centers can involve huge capital investments and major construction work, but they often create relatively few permanent jobs. That makes the construction phase the central employment impact of the project.

If public resources are involved, agreements should require project labor agreements, prevailing wages, local hiring, jobsite safety standards, and participation in state-certified apprenticeships. Permanent jobs should also carry job-quality standards: good wages, benefits, direct employment where possible, and first source hiring access for local residents.

This is not anti-growth. It is how communities build capacity for growth.

Data centers do not exist in a separate labor market. When they draw from the same pool of electricians, pipefitters, and other skilled workers without investing in training, they worsen skills shortages for everyone else. Responsible deals should grow the workforce, not simply consume it.

It hurts the economy.

Bove 26 [Tristan Bove is a contributing reporter on Fortune's news team. Tristan graduated with degrees in International Studies and Chinese from DePaul University, and previously was Policy & Economics Editor at Earth.Org, an environmental journalism non-profit. He has lived and worked in the U.S., Italy, and Hong Kong.] Bove, Tristan. “Data Centers Are Dealing Hidden Damage to Environmental and Public Health—Costing the Economy \$25 Billion Every Year.” *Fortune*, 21 Apr. 2026, <https://fortune.com/2026/04/21/data-centers-environmental-health-costs-25-billion/>. Accessed 14 July 2026.//celery

In North America, the sprawling server farms used to train and run artificial intelligence models received a \$47 billion investment surge last year, building out everything from cooling equipment to plumbing. The tech companies at the center of the data center craze, such as Meta and Google, took out \$182 billion in loans last year to fund their splurge, double what they borrowed in 2024. One of the primary criticisms

of the data center construction craze has been its environmental effect, including the facilities' impact on water, land, and electricity use. But that cost might also directly affect local residents and their health, according to findings from a National Bureau of Economic Research working paper published earlier this month. The analysis of around 2,800 operational data centers was authored by Nicholas Muller, an economist at Carnegie Mellon University. Muller tracked data centers' electricity needs last year and found how much air pollution and additional planet-warming greenhouse gases local grids generated to supply that demand. The author derived indicators, such as the risk of premature mortality associated with data centers' electricity needs, and converted those measurements into dollar amounts using standard estimates, such as the social cost of carbon, which measures the economic damage of each additional ton of carbon released into the atmosphere. The result is that data centers' environmental damage last year cost the economy at large \$25 billion, of which \$3.7 billion is directly tied to AI activities in data centers. This price tag represents an externality—an indirect consequence of economic activity that imposes costs on third parties not directly involved in the original activity. Rather than reflecting an increase in day-to-day medical expenses or higher taxes to subsidize a greater need for care, Muller's analysis boils down the cost of premature deaths tied to the environmental impact of data centers, assigning an economic value to the resulting shortened life expectancy.

Infrastructure is k2 solving poverty and promoting access to crucial services

Straub et. al. 25 [Stéphane Straub, Tomás Serebrisky, Lisa Bagnoli and Claudio Rojas, 3/7/25, [Stéphane Straub is the Chief Economist for Infrastructure at the World Bank Group. Tomás Serebrisky is a Principal Economic Advisor at the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB) specializing in infrastructure and transportation. Lisa Bagnoli and Claudio Rojas are economists with the World Bank and IDB who research infrastructure, public investment, and economic development. Together, they authored this report for two of the world's leading development institutions.] "Infrastructure and Poverty Reduction: Innovative policies for effective access", World Bank, [https://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/infrastructure/publication/infrastructure-and-poverty-reduction-innovative-policies?\[/RG](https://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/infrastructure/publication/infrastructure-and-poverty-reduction-innovative-policies?[/RG)

A wealth of accumulated evidence shows that access to basic infrastructure services such as electricity, roads, and digital connectivity, as well as water, sanitation, and hygiene, is crucial for development and has a substantial impact on household welfare and poverty alleviation. Numerous studies have established that these services provide households with critical opportunities to learn, receive good quality healthcare, and access jobs and that they enable businesses to operate efficiently, engage in trade, and access markets. In addition, infrastructure generates important indirect effects through agglomeration economies in cities, including access to ideas and innovation, education, health, gender equality, and resilience in the face of economic and environmental shocks. Qualitative reviews by the World Bank, which examined more than 300 studies conducted between 1983 and 2022, investigated the impact that digital, power, and transport infrastructure have on economic growth and social development (Foster et al. 2023a, 2023b). According to the authors, most evidence suggests that improvements in infrastructure play a crucial role in supporting the development process. In addition, the impact of growth, which remains a main driver of poverty reduction (Dollar, Kleineberg, and Kraay 2016; Crespo Cuaresma, Klasen, and Wacker 2022), appears to be robust across sectors, as shown in a meta-analysis by Foster et al. (2023b). Finally, being cut off from basic infrastructure services has direct implications for poverty. Box 1.1 discusses one way to assess this direct effect through the concept of multidimensional poverty. This evidence must be considered in a context in which, despite impressive progress in recent decades steered by initiatives such as the Millennium Development Goals and then the Sustainable Development Goals, there are still billions of people who lack access to essential infrastructure services.

Subpoint C is Utilities:

Hyperscale data centers increase utility bills

Greenfield 26 (Nicole Greenfield, 3/20/26 [As an investigative reporter at Consumer Reports, Nicole covers environmental health, food safety, and sustainability] Consumer Reports. “AI Data Centers: Big Tech's Impact on Electric Bills, Water, and More” <https://www.consumerreports.org/data-centers/ai-data-centers-impact-on-electric-bills-water-and-more-a1040338678/> //SF)

Residential prices jumped 7.1 percent in 2025—more than **double the inflation rate—and topped 20 percent** in some states, according to federal data. The AI data center rush isn't the only factor driving up prices—others include inflation and an aging power grid—but it's a significant one. **That's because hyperscale data centers demand a nearly unimaginable amount of energy.** The International Energy Agency says **a typical hyperscale data center might use 100 megawatts (MW), as much electricity as 100,000 households.** And that's at the low end. **Meta's Hyperion project** in Louisiana, for instance, will need at least 5 GW to run. That's **three times as much electricity as the entire city of New Orleans,** according to the Institute on Taxation and Economic Policy. **By 2028, data centers could use 12 percent of all the electricity consumed in the U.S.,** according to the Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory, and that percentage will grow. More regions could start to look like Virginia, already home to nearly 600 facilities with more than 100 more proposed or under construction. According to a Bloomberg News analysis, data centers accounted for almost 40 percent of the state's total consumption in 2024. More data centers can mean higher costs. That same Bloomberg analysis found that **areas with high concentrations of data centers saw electricity prices jump 267 percent over the past five years.** And John Steinbach isn't the only Virginia resident to see a connection: Nearly three-quarters of voters in the state Electricity Law Initiative and co-author of a March 2025 paper exploring how the public is funding Big Tech's power-intensive facilities. “Utilities are building infrastructure, and then we all pay for it because that's how the utility business model has always worked,” he says. **Residential electricity costs are also rising because the rush of new hyperscale data centers wanting to draw power from the grid is spiking blame the facilities,** largely clustered in Northern Virginia's Data Center Alley, for rising electricity costs, according to a January 2026 survey conducted by Global Strategy Group and the Chesapeake Climate Action Network Action Fund. The worry extends beyond Virginia, too. A November 2025 nationally representative survey (PDF) of 2,146 U.S. adults by Consumer Reports found that **78 percent of Americans are somewhat or very concerned that the new data centers being built across the country will make their energy bills go up.** To keep up with the growing demand for power, electric utilities are spending billions to build new transmission lines and power plants. That's one of the main ways new data centers can drive up home electricity bills, says Ari Peskoe, director of Harvard Law School's demand. That drives up prices for everyone, Peskoe says.

Unaffordable utility bills exacerbate risks

Hernández & Bird 10 (Diana Hernández and Stephen Bird, 11/2010 [Hernández is an Associate Professor of Sociomedical Sciences, Columbia University, Mailman School of Public Health. Stephen Bird is Associate Professor of Political Science at Clarkson University] PMC PubMed Central. “Energy Burden and the Need for Integrated Low-Income Housing and Energy Policy” <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4819257/#S10> //SF)

Research on energy insecurity lends insight into how this experience may lead to **future poverty** spells. Hernández (2016) provided a conceptual framework, outlining the economic components of energy insecurity Energy Burden and Economic Poverty in the US 3 and the various burdens to which it exposes households. **In addition to the health consequences of living in cold, dark, and damp conditions, which can lead to debt accumulation or lost wages, Hernández (2016) found that many energy insecure residents prioritize housing payments and food costs over utility bills when forced to choose** (a point reinforced by Finnigan and Meagher 2019). The resulting **utility debt** can lead to an **economic cycle of “playing catch up.”** Such debt **can limit the ability to secure new housing** as arrears can prevent the transfer of utility services to new addresses, potentially locking households into structurally inefficient homes, **and demanding resources that households could otherwise invest in avoiding or transitioning out of poverty** (work-related capital, schooling, or training, etc.). **Utility disconnection is also linked with increased risk of eviction** (Desmond 2016; Finnigan and Meagher 2019), **food insecurity, telephone disconnection, unmet medical needs, and other forms of material hardship** (Heflin 2006). In the case of eviction, Desmond's (2016) qualitative research in Milwaukee, Wisconsin finds that **evictions spike in the summer and early fall when low-income households prioritize catching up on their utility bills to avoid disconnection before the winter shut-off moratorium begins,** and evictions decline over the winter when households can stop paying their utility bill without risking a disconnection. Interviews conducted by Hernández (2016) of low-income families revealed **utility bills cumulating to thousands of dollars, restricting discretionary income, and putting households into long-term debt.** In their ethnographic research, Harrison and Popke (2011) shed light on the challenges of energy-burdened households deciding between paying utility bills and covering their medical and nutritional needs. At a meso-level, the experience of energy burden can prevent families from moving out of low-resource neighborhoods and establishing social connections that facilitate economic opportunity. While social networks can provide private safety nets that help mitigate the consequences of triggering events (Heflin, London, and Scott 2011), a large majority of Americans experiencing missed utility payments report receiving no outside help; of those who do, about half receive support from friends and family (Finnigan and Meagher 2019). **Researchers have linked inadequate access to affordable energy with household food insecurity** (Cook et al. 2008; Bhattacharya et al. 2003), **health and child development risks** (Cook et al. 2008; Hernández 2013; Hernández 2016), **social network disruption** (Harrison and Popke 2011), **and mortality during heat waves** (Klinenberg 2002). The trade-off between paying energy bills and sacrificing basic needs is documented across several pieces of research. A US Energy Information

Administration report indicated that about a third of households faced challenges in paying their energy bill in 2015, and about a fifth of households reduced or forwent basic necessities for at least a month to pay their energy bill (U.S. EIA 2015). A whitepaper produced for the Senate Committee on Energy and Natural Resources explored how **energy costs can push families to poverty** entry or cause **food insecurity** (Murkowski and Scott 2014). A statewide report in Colorado 4 **Social Forces** found the **inability to pay utility bills** as **one of the leading causes of homelessness** behind job loss and family breakup (Center for Education Policy Analysis 2006). **Utility shutoffs can exacerbate or cause illness** (Hernández and Bird 2010), and **landlords** may use **disconnection** as grounds for **eviction** in some **circumstances** (Verclas and Hsieh 2018). Eviction, food insecurity, and other material hardships often associated with energy burdens could initiate or prolong a cycle of poverty. **The inability to access affordable energy services can prevent participation in certain economic activities and serve as a barrier to upward mobility** (Sovacool, Sidortsov, and Jones 2014). We suggest that **energy burdens may be one of several triggering events preceding poverty** entry (Bane and Ellwood 1986; DiPrete and McManus 2000).